

production shown here was staged by the Hamburg State Opera in 2014.

Italian adventures

Following the success of his first attempt at opera, *Almira*, staged at the Hamburg opera house in 1705 to great acclaim, Handel traveled to Italy, Europe's leading center of vocal music, in 1707. He mixed in the fashionable society of Florence, Rome, Venice, and Naples, exciting great admiration with his virtuoso performances on the organ. He may have conducted a love affair with a Florentine singer, Vittoria Tarquini; if true, this was his only known liaison.

Musically, his stay in Italy completed his education; he learned to compose operas in the current Italian style, designed to showcase the virtuosity of castrati (see box) and sopranos. His *Agrippina*, performed in Venice in 1709–1710, was a triumphant success.

“ Never has perfection in any art been combined in the same man with such fertility of production. ”

ANTOINE PREVOST, ON HANDEL, 1733